It was the first time since arriving in Germany that she'd heard someone speak of pain as if it was something to avoid. "Yes, it seems to be painful for her. How can I find this Euphrasia?"

"Come by the sick bay in the morning—it's on the ground floor of the barracks next to the train station—I'll have the poultice ready with some instructions in German." He tipped his hat. "If you arrive before your factory shift starts, I'll have more time to explain."

"I will. Thank you."

He crossed the street and disappeared into the darkness.

"Who was that?" Rose asked.

"A doctor, I think." Why hadn't she asked his name?

"Is he French?"

"He speaks it well. I'll find out tomorrow. Come, let's go." Despite the cold and bitter wind, she felt warmed by the gentleman's kindness. As they passed the river, she listened to the sound of rushing water echoing beneath the snow and realized it had been a pleasure to speak French again and even more to learn something that might help others. Their footsteps quickened as the wind picked up, and Léa glanced at the sky, noticing silver flakes twirling through the darkness.

Snow. The light flakes melted on contact with the ground. Léa had disliked the snow, especially how it turned to ice overnight, making the morning walk to the factory treacherous. But now it felt softer and she didn't mind so much. She even looked up, letting the flakes fall on her face before turning away from the river to the barracks.

* * *

The next morning, Léa got up extra early before the throng of women descended on the zinc trough. She combed her hair out, then wove the long brown strands into a single braid. She put on her uniform, apron and overcoat and set off early. She wanted enough time to stop by the sick bay before going to the factory.

It had snowed overnight, and the sidewalk was icy, so she took small steps to avoid slipping. The cold turned the sky crystal blue, and sunlight shimmered on the windows.

She found the barracks next to the train station, passing armed soldiers